

Constraint here measures how few people you know, not how closed they are

Burt's constraint against the number of co-members, for the 724 people in the co-membership giant component with 40 or fewer. The two move together almost mechanically ($r = -0.82$): the 24 people at the top of the chart are simply those with a single contact, for whom constraint is 1 by definition.

Median constraint is 0.32, roughly what three unconnected contacts would give. Reach for constraint here and you will mostly re-measure degree — the record rarely gives an ego network rich enough for the measure to bite.

